Pricing, Without Apology

A guide to what to charge and how to quote it.

A FIELD GUIDE FOR PRICING CREATIVE AND CONSULTATIVE WORK

01 The condition

Most pricing trouble begins before the client is in the room. A number gets chosen by how it feels to say, not by what the work costs, and a few months later the business is quietly paying for the privilege of being busy.

Pricing has two parts. The arithmetic, which is calm and knowable. And the moment of saying the number, which is where most people discount before anyone has asked them to.

This sample covers the first part of each. Start with the floor, the rate below which you are paying to work.

02 How to use this sample

Use real monthly figures, not hoped-for ones. Count billable hours honestly: admin, email and sick days are not billable, even though they are work.

03 The cost floor

A Monthly costs of running the business _____

B What you need to pay yourself each month _____

C Share set aside for tax and savings (as a decimal, e.g. 0.30) _____

D Realistic billable hours per month _____

THE FLOOR

Hourly floor = (A + B) ÷ (1 – C) ÷ D

Example: costs $1,200, pay $4,000, set-aside 0.30, 60 hours.
(1,200 + 4,000) ÷ 0.70 ÷ 60 = **about $124 an hour.**

Your floor _____ per hour

SAYING THE NUMBER

“For this scope, the fee is [amount]. That includes [what’s included]. Anything beyond that, I’ll quote separately before starting.”

The right set-aside depends on where you live and how you’re registered. An accountant can give you the figure in one conversation.

THE FULL FIELD GUIDE

This is a two-page sample of *Pricing, Without Apology*, a 18-page field guide. The full version also holds:

— Value pricing, and when it fits better than hours
— Building tiers that protect the work
— Quoting, discounts, and what to say when a client pushes back

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